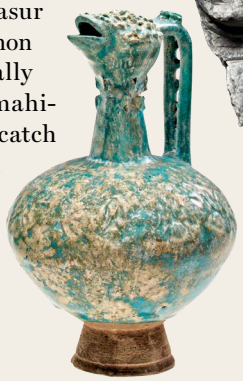
EXHIBITION ▼

FINDING COMMON GROUND

Artefacts from ROME'S MUSEO DELLE CIVILTÀ at Delhi's Humayun's Tomb Museum reveal the cultural exchanges between ancient civilisations







At the Humayun's Tomb Museum in Delhi, a most curious artefact leads the ongoing exhibition *Shared Stories: An Art Journey Across Civilizations Beyond Boundaries*. This is a fragment of a statue of the Hindu goddess Durga in her 'Mahishasur Mardini' aspect, slaying the demon Mahishasur who is traditionally drawn with a buffalo-head ('mahi-sha' = buffalo and so on). The catch is, this Durga-fragment is from Afghanistan, dating back to the 9th-11th century AD, and was discovered in a Buddhist monastery. An accompanying plaque calls Afghanistan "a historic crossroads shaped by Greek foundations, Kushana cosmopolitanism, Shahi and Hindu-Shahi patronage, and later the Ghaznavid court".

This is precisely the kind of artefact you'll find in *Shared Stories*, an exhibition that specialises in cases of cultural hybridity, cross-pollination and the free exchange of ideas and motifs across civilisations. It's a collaborative effort between the Humayun's Tomb Museum, the Italian Institute of Culture and Museo delle



A DELICATE BLOSSOM
'The Rhododendrons of Sikkim-Himalaya', 1849 and (right) 'Averrhoa carambola', late 19th-century

EXHIBITION ▶

Flora Indica

A new show at the Museum of Art and Photography, Bengaluru, leans in to the 'garden city' moniker

Bengaluru erupts in colour in March, when Tabebuia rosea, Yellow Tabebuia and Jacaranda trees are in full bloom. This year is special, as a new show—*Paper Gardens: Art, Botany, and Empire*—adds an artistic flourish to the season. This is a two-gallery exhibition at the Museum of Art & Photography (MAP), Bengaluru, that has been close to two years in the making and is curated by Shrey Maurya, research director, Impart. With over a hundred exhibits consisting of artwork, textiles, prints and botanical volumes, this is the first time a show of this size focusing on botanical illustrations from the colonial period is being showcased in India.

The works date from the late 1600s to the late 20th century and are from MAP's collection, with a few reproductions. "Most of what you see are not paintings, but original hand-coloured lithographs," says Maurya. The first gallery examines how an interest in plants